RADIO & COMMUNICATIONS

Getting emergency information and staying in touch with your household when phones and internet are down or overloaded.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General preparedness information, not a substitute for professional training, local rules, manufacturer instructions or medical care. **Practice skills in safe conditions before you need them, and verify important information with current official sources.**

1. GETTING INFORMATION

SOURCE	WHAT IT IS	TIPS
Wireless Emergency Alerts	Alerts pushed to cell phones in an area: weather warnings, evacuations, AMBER alerts.	Free and automatic. Keep them turned on in your phone's settings.
NOAA Weather Radio	National Weather Service broadcasts, 24 hours a day, on 7 frequencies between 162.400 and 162.550 MHz.	Get a radio with battery backup and an alert tone. "SAME" models alert only for your county.
AM / FM radio	Local stations carry the Emergency Alert System and local news. AM travels farther, especially at night.	Write your local emergency stations below. A crank or solar radio needs no batteries.
Local alerts	County and city text and email alerts.	Sign up before you need them.

2. PHONES WHEN NETWORKS ARE BUSY

- **Text** instead of calling. Texts often get through when calls fail.
- Keep calls short, to leave lines open for emergencies.
- Call or text **one out-of-area contact**: often easier to reach than local numbers. Everyone reports to that person. *(DC-01)*
- Call 911 only for emergencies. Where text-to-911 is available, it is for when calling isn't possible: **call if you can, text if you can't**.
- Update your voicemail greeting with your status.
- Keep phones charged. *(TR-07)*

3. TWO-WAY RADIOS

SERVICE	LICENSE	WHAT IT'S GOOD FOR	KNOW THIS
FRS	None	Inexpensive handheld "walkie-talkies" for family use: around the house, neighborhood, campground.	22 channels. Up to 2 watts on most channels, 0.5 watt on channels 8 to 14. Real range is usually under a mile or two among buildings and trees; more over open ground. Box claims are best case.
GMRS	FCC license; no exam; covers your immediate family; 10 years	More power and range than FRS, larger antennas and vehicle radios, and repeaters that extend range.	Shares channels with FRS. Apply on the FCC website; check the current fee there.
CB	None	Vehicle radios; truckers and travelers on highways.	40 channels. **Channel 9 is for emergencies**; channel 19 is the highway channel.

Amateur ("ham") radio	FCC license; exam required	The most capable option: local, regional and worldwide communication, much of it independent of phone and internet systems.	The entry-level license is the Technician class. Local clubs teach classes, and volunteer emergency groups (ARES, RACES) support communities in disasters.

4. USING A RADIO WELL

- Listen first: make sure the channel is clear before you talk.
- Press the button, wait a second, then speak. Keep it short.
- Say who you're calling, then who you are: "Base, this is Car Two."
- Use plain language. Say "over" when you want a reply.
- Set **check-in times**, such as the first 5 minutes of every hour, and turn radios off between them to save batteries.
- Choose a main channel and a backup channel before you need them.
- Practice with your family a few times a year.
- Never give out information you wouldn't want strangers to hear: anyone can listen.

5. OUR COMMUNICATION CARD

Out-of-area contact (name / number)	
Local AM / FM emergency stations	
NOAA Weather Radio frequency here	
Family radio: main channel / backup channel	
Check-in times	
Call signs (who is who on the radio)	
If we can't reach each other, we will	

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. Federal Communications Commission: Family Radio Service; General Mobile Radio Service; Citizens Band; Amateur Radio Service; Text to 911; Tips for Communicating in an Emergency. `fcc.gov`
2. NOAA National Weather Service: NOAA Weather Radio. `weather.gov/nwr`
3. FEMA: Ready.gov: Make a Plan; Emergency Alerts. `ready.gov/alerts`
4. ARRL, the national association for amateur radio: getting licensed; ARES. `arrl.org`

IMPORTANT: Radio rules and fees are set by the FCC and can change. Check fcc.gov before buying or applying. This document reflects the sources above as of November 2026.